GASTROBAR · KIROVA 10 · YAROSLAVL

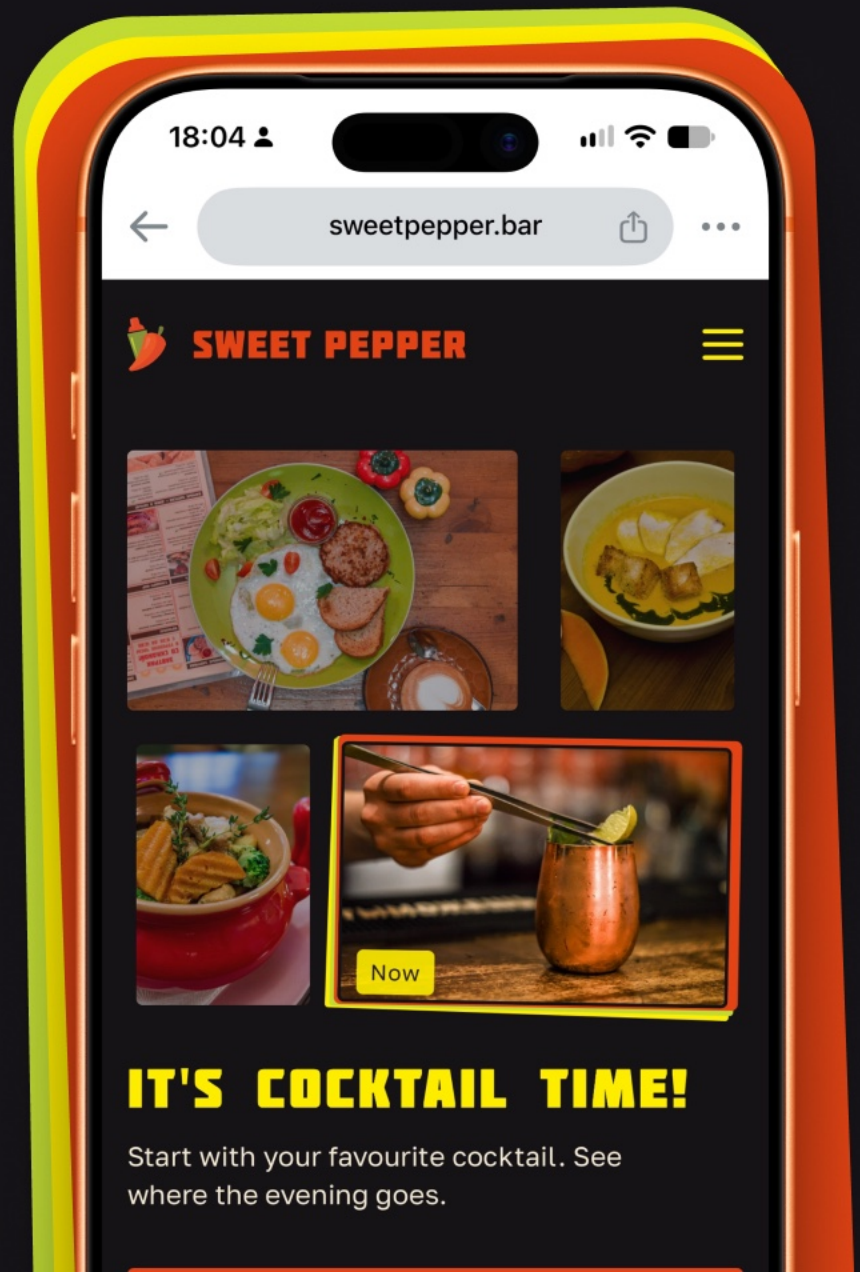
SWEET PEPPER

BRAND & UX CASE STUDY

Systemizing a beloved but chaotic gastrobar identity, then designing and building a full website that changes with the time of day.

- ON THE BAR'S DOMAIN · RU + EN

Role: Brand & Web Designer · Timeline: Jun–Oct 2026 · Updated Oct 20



CONTENTS

SIX CHAPTERS, AS THEY HAPPENED

01 The story — one venue, four identities, a 50/50 split

02 Design system — three hues, two faces, a ledger of rules

03 Strategy — heat = time, the platform, two languages

04 Figma stage — the hero that outlived its widget

05 Building with AI — files steer, the browser is the bench

06 Real use — the law, the team's admin, the slider's return



THE STORY



DESIGN SYSTEM



STRATEGY



FIGMA STAGE



BUILDING WITH AI



REAL USE

CHAPTER 1 OF 6

THE STORY

CONTEXT

A HYBRID, NOT A TEMPLATE

Sweet Pepper isn't a café that also serves drinks, or a bar that does brunch on weekends. It was built from day one to run breakfast, business lunch, after-work drinks, and late-night cocktails with equal intentionality — a 50/50 kitchen-to-bar revenue split, maintained deliberately for years.

That structural duality — one venue, four distinct daily identities — became the central design problem: how does a single homepage represent a breakfast spot, a lunch destination, an evening bar, and a late-night hang without picking one and alienating the rest?

4.6/5
Google rating · 1,300+ reviews

50/50
Kitchen-to-bar revenue split

8:30-LATE
Daily operating window

THE CHALLENGE

FOUR PROBLEMS, ONE HOMEPAGE

01 · NO SYSTEM, JUST ARTIFACTS

12 years of logos, posters, and menus existed — but no shared color logic, no type hierarchy, no rules for reuse.

02 · A PALETTE THAT FIGHTS ITSELF

Chili red, lime, and lemon are loud individually. Left unsystematized, saturated color-on-color fails contrast and fatigues the eye.

03 · ONE VENUE, FOUR IDENTITIES

Breakfast, lunch, evening bar, and late-night party each need different tone, imagery, and CTA — inside a single hero.

04 · GENERIC TEMPLATE GRAVITY

Early drafts kept defaulting to stock restaurant-site patterns: hero photo + headline + card grid — nothing that felt like this specific bar.

CHAPTER 2 OF 6

DESIGN SYSTEM

A LITTLE COSY.
A LITTLE SPICY.

Warm, soulful, familiar meets loud, playful, a little rough.
Good food & drink since 2014. Shake & Cook.

01 / Color System

RED · CHILI

Paprika	Chili	Deep Chili
#EF6D44	#E34314	#9B2705

GREEN · LIME

Light Lime	Lime	Avocado	Olive
#D4E671	#C1DB34	#869438	#737D3A

YELLOW · LEMON

Lemon	Cream
#FFED00	#FFF689

NEUTRAL GROUNDS

Peppercorn	Parchment	Paper
#151317	#F3E9D2	#FCF7E8

02 / Typography

MOLOT

The signature heavy, condensed voice. Short all-caps headlines only.

Golos Text

The readable voice for body, menus and UI. Warm, clear, understated.

03 / Day & Night Modes

DAY · KITCHEN

COME HUNGRY

Your table. Your favourites.

Warm, soft, still bold

NIGHT · BAR

STAY LATE

Your next round starts here.

Bold, lively, stll welcoming

04 / Spacing

Edges, gaps, icons size = to multiples of 4px.

4 8 12 16 24 32

05 / Photography

Photography direction: shoot in the bar. Warm directional light, shallow depth of field.

SOLUTION · IDENTITY

KEEP THE MARK, BUILD AROUND IT

The chili-and-shaker mark and the bottle-cap seal already had years of recognition and guest affection — the research showed no reason to replace them. The job was consolidation: one clear hierarchy of lockups, one clear-space rule, minimum sizes, and defined backgrounds, so the mark could scale from a favicon to a storefront sign without improvisation.



Before

SYSTEMIZED INTO SIX LOCKUPS →



After — one of six defined lockups

PROCESS · SELF-AUDIT

RECOMPUTE YOUR OWN CLAIMS

FOUND — QUEUED TO FIX

The interaction rule was false

“Exactly three tappable styles” forbade five things already designed — tiles, stamps, the word cloud. Fix: a closed, sanctioned exception list. The value was never the number; it’s the list being closed.

The price colour fails AA

Olive prices on Parchment measure 3.68:1 in exactly the small-text menu rows they were assigned to. A token decision — Deep Chili or a darker green step — queued before any CSS variable is written.

“Colour-blind safe” wasn’t

Under protanopia, Chili and Olive — day’s two accents, adjacent on every menu row — collapse from ΔE 78 to 10. The claim narrows to what’s testable: no colour carries meaning alone.

THE DISCIPLINE

Findings only, nothing changed

Eleven files cross-checked; where documents disagree, both sides are named and the current one identified. The calls stay the author’s — the audit changed no doc silently.

Numbers re-derived, not trusted

Contrast ratios and colour-vision claims recomputed from the hex values per the project’s own standing instruction — the tables had drifted from the math.

A work order, not a report card

A-items would ship bugs or wrong guest-facing facts; B-items block specific build phases; C is hygiene — and one section lists what came back clean, so the rest can still be trusted.

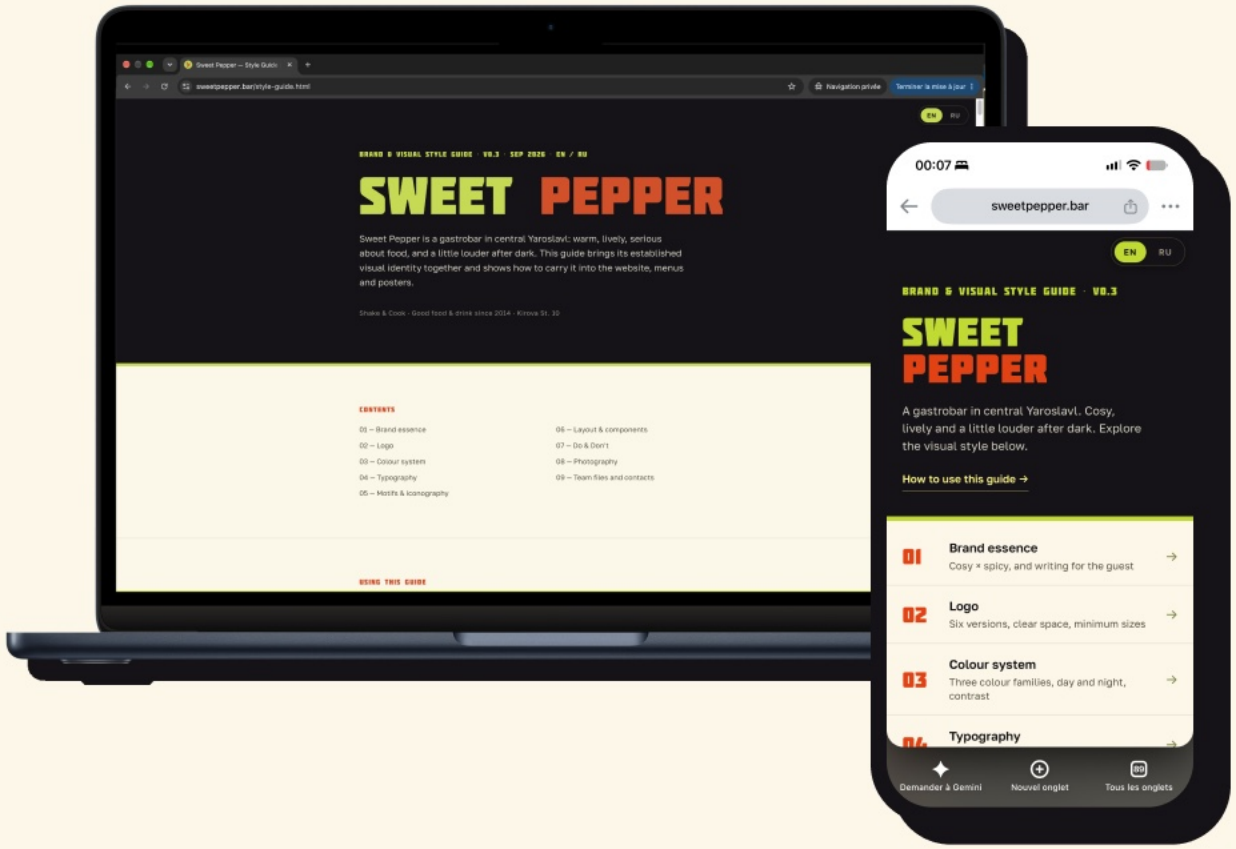
THE SYSTEM SHIPS AS A PRODUCT

ONE FILE, TWO LANGUAGES

Live on the bar's domain: a single-file bilingual guide — EN and RU as layers with a language switch — an app-style mobile shell under 768px, and A4 PDFs (EN 27pp, RU 30pp) from a scripted render pipeline. An in-page edit mode commits text fixes straight to the repo from the live page.

IF IT'S MISSED, DRAW IT

The logo clear-space rule existed in text and a teammate missed it — so it became a drawn four-card figure, constructed at load time from the artwork itself, exact even if a logo is swapped. Documentation failures are design problems, not reader problems.



CHAPTER 3 OF 6

STRATEGY

THE INSIGHT

USE THE CLOCK, NOT A MOMENT

Every static draft forced a choice: show the cocktail bar and lose the breakfast crowd, or show breakfast and bury the thing everyone actually remembers the place for. The reframe: the venue already changes its whole identity four times a day — breakfast, lunch, dinner, party. So let the website do the same thing, automatically, tied to the guest's real local time.

One constraint shaped the mechanic more than any other: hospitality's "no-clock rule" — good service makes guests lose track of time, so the hero could never show a literal clock or countdown. The heat slider solves this by implying time through a metaphor (mild → on fire) instead of stating it.

BREAKFAST

mild

LUNCH

warm

DINNER

spicy

PARTY

on fire

SOLUTION · RU LAYER & CONTENT OPS

SHIPPING IN TWO LANGUAGES

A VOICE, NOT A TRANSLATION

The Russian layer is a system

A voice-and-vocabulary doc distils the bar's own social-media voice into checkable rules, with a per-line test for new copy. RU and EN stay register twins — the wink carries over, never the words.

A contradiction, held openly

The guest-perspective rule and the venue's natural «мы» collide harder in Russian than in English. The voice doc records the tension where future drafts can see it, instead of resolving it by fiat.

Even the display layer is bilingual

The giant outlined Molot connectors exist as separately drawn RU SVGs for every section — built for the language, not string-swapped.

CONTENT OPS, TESTED FOR REAL

The admin got usability-tested too

Menu storage — repeater vs dish posts — tested with two team members on the real WordPress admin. Dish posts won; the prediction on record lost, and the log admits it. The loser is archived, not deleted.

The VK importer, evidence first

Built with an evidence table before any live run: re-imports idempotent, hand edits surviving source edits, images self-hosted at 4:5. It now runs hourly by itself. EN stays manual — the languages never share a pipeline dependency.

Keys treated like keys

An exposed credential was revoked and replaced the day it happened; failures are logged without secrets in a status line the team can actually read.

SOLUTION · INFORMATION ARCHITECTURE

THE HERO ISN'T THE WHOLE PAGE

With the hero mechanic proven, the homepage grew to its full shape: seven sections carrying the brand's actual content priorities, mapped before layout began.

1. Hero — the spice slider
2. Community Hits — permanent-by-guest-demand menu items
3. Home Made Infusions — the bar's signature craft proof
4. Seasonal Kitchen Menu — the food's quiet-retention story
5. The Pepper Story — About-page teaser
6. News, Parties, Promos — manual social feed mirror
7. Find Us — map, reservation form, hours, footer

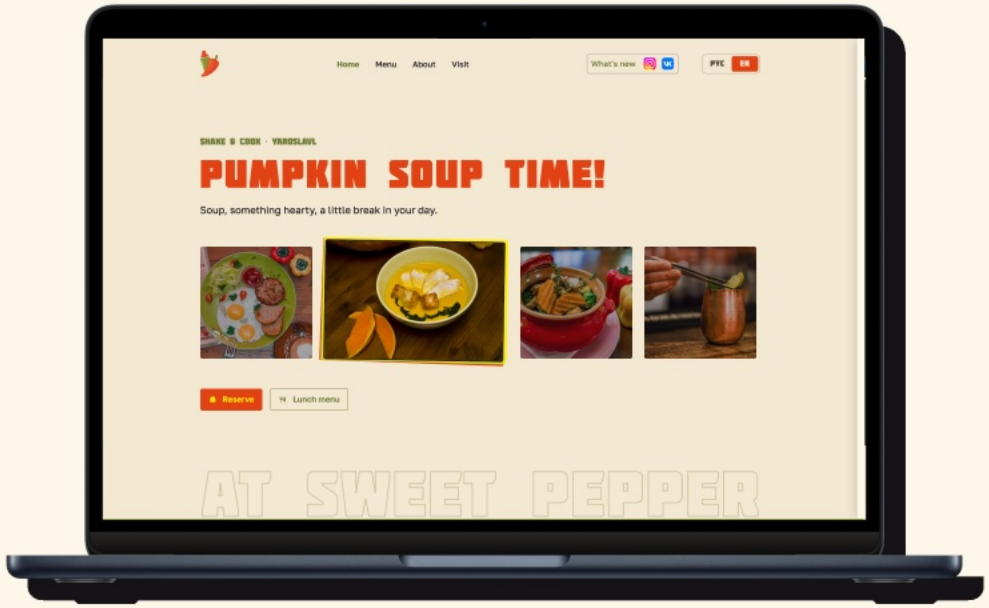


CHAPTER 4 OF 6

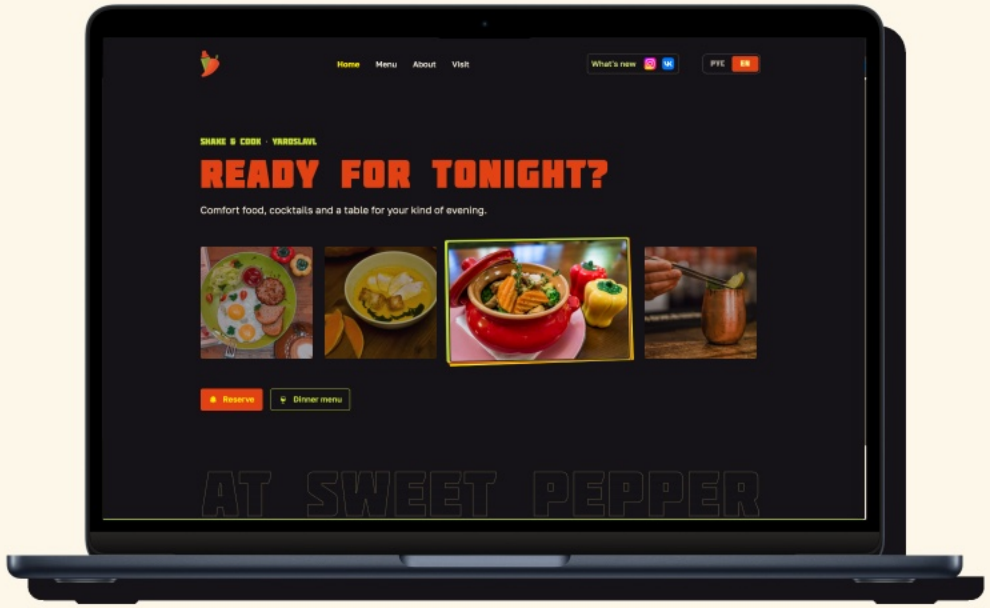
FIGMA STAGE

ONE HERO, TWO STATES

The heat slider came first; a participant called it “too complicated”, and a four-tile photo grid won the A/B — heat = time, the state model and the day/night flip survived the swap. Then the browser refined it: the cards grew until the selected tile carried the composition.



DAY — “YUMMY MORNING!”



NIGHT — “READY FOR TONIGHT?”

SOLUTION · MENU PAGE

TESTED, NOT GUESSED

WON — SIDE-NAV POSTER

All sections visible at once

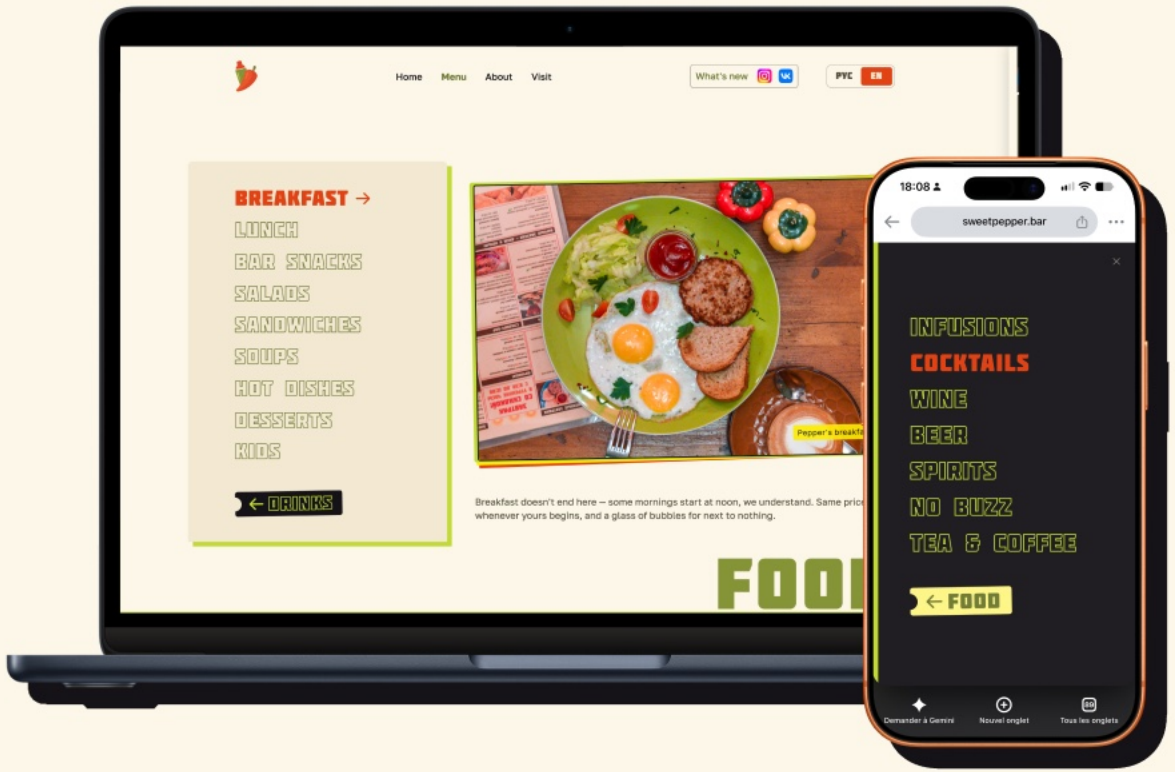
Won stakeholder A/B + usability testing on the page's stated KPI — time-to-dish. A Parchment nav panel merges into the content it navigates; photos stack on tilted Lemon + Chili sheets.

Two independent axes

Content state (food/drinks) × theme (day/night) never lock — kitchen content at 9pm is kitchen content in night clothes. Time proposes, memory disposes.

Soups: a separate section

Testing showed guests could find soups under Hot dishes but agreed they don't belong there — an accepted, documented web↔print divergence.



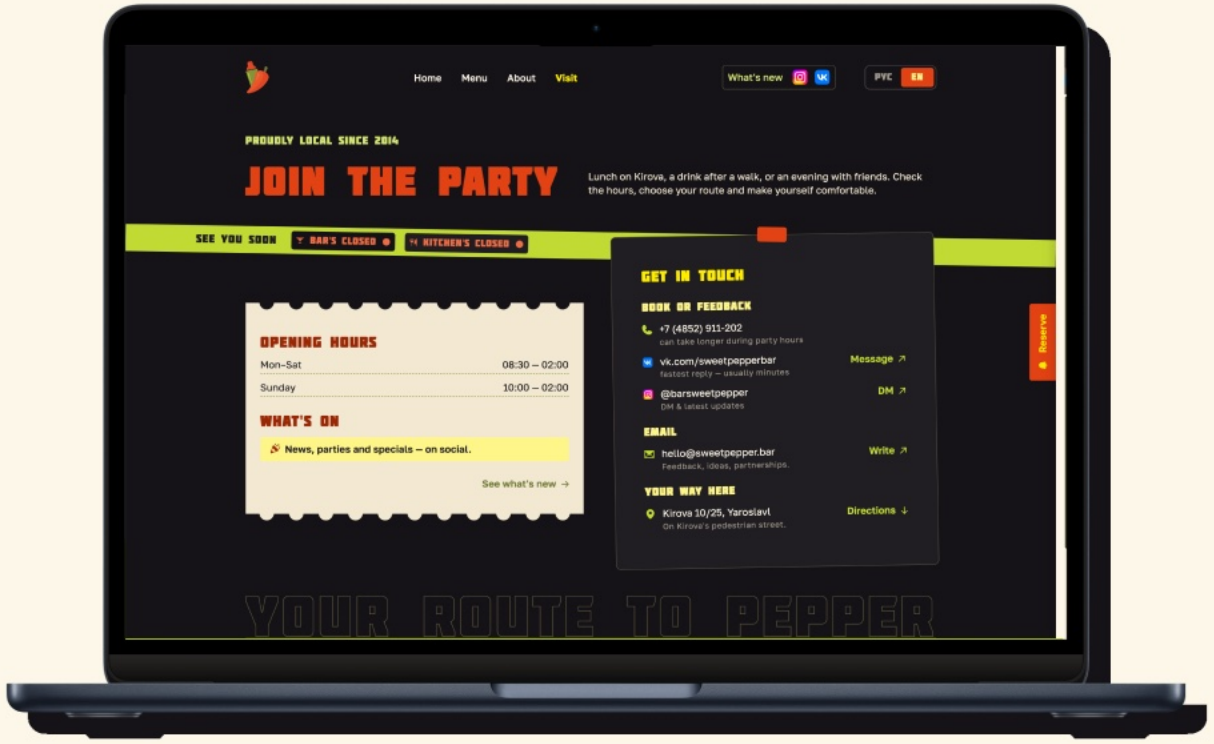
THE INTERFACE ANSWERS LIKE THE BAR

THE BARTENDER'S TICKET

An order slip the interface “prints” to answer the guest — the kitchen–bar handshake made tangible. Always Paper, day or night (a receipt is paper regardless of the hour), so on dark grounds it’s the brightest object in view: max one per viewport. The reply is always a person speaking, never a template.

ONE MOTION LANGUAGE

Outline → fill is the one state change everywhere — slider labels, nav words, the word cloud. One idle clock per section: untouched sections demo themselves; any interaction seizes the clock. Spring easing, transforms only; reduced-motion keeps state changes and drops the theatre.



SOLUTION · MOBILE

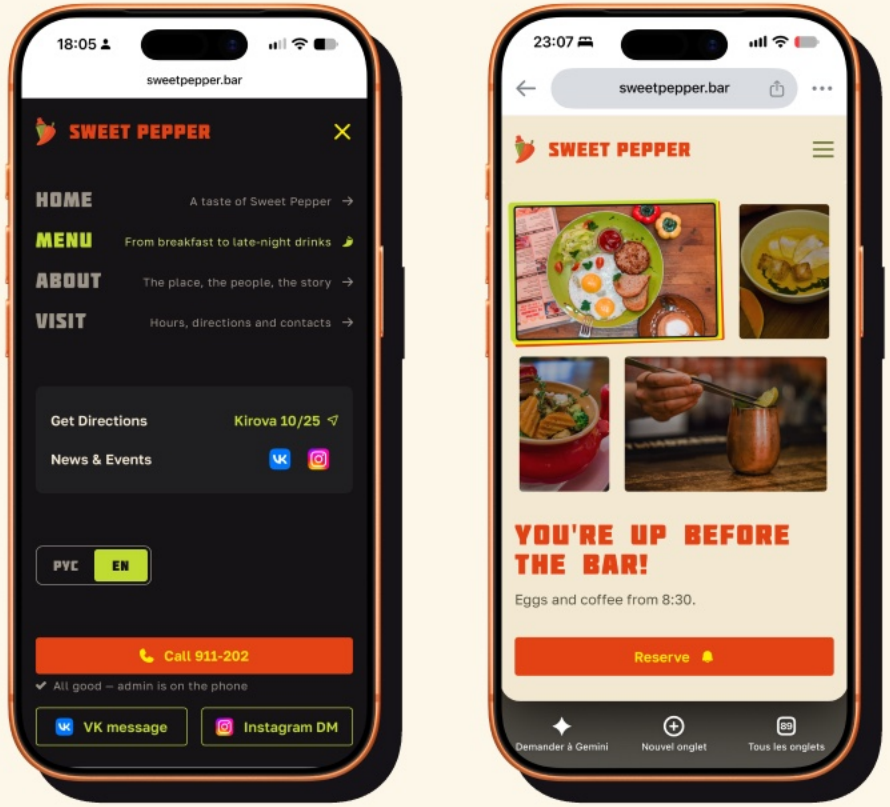
SAME RULES, ONE HAND

THE DRAWER

Four nav items collapse into a full-screen drawer that themes by time like every surface — Molot items with guest-voice descriptions, outline → fill marking “you are here” (readable in greyscale; colour never carries state alone), and a booking block where phone leads: Russian guests book by call.

TOUCH SPLITS PREVIEW FROM COMMIT

The menu hero’s no-CTA rule turned out to be scoped to pointer input: hover and click are two channels, touch has one — a word can’t be both preview and commit. On touch, tapping a word previews and a boxed action commits; the active word drops its arrow, because on touch it isn’t the action.



CHAPTER 5 OF 6

BUILDING WITH AI

SOLUTION · BUILD

THE SPEC BECOMES CODE

A CLASSIC THEME, RUNNING

A classic WordPress theme runs locally with Vite compiling tokens straight from design.md. The day/night mechanic, the tile-grid hero, the side-nav menu hero and its doors, nine food sections plus the bar menu, and the rugged-edge ticket all exist as working template parts.

DOCS AS THE INTERFACE

The theme is built one chat per section, steered by files rather than chat history: a living project report whose first line is “read this before writing any code,” agent briefs, and subagents. Git pushes go through Claude Code — every session starts from current truth, not archaeology.

THE AUDIT PAID OFF FIRST

The A-list ran ahead of the first line of CSS: the interaction-rule exception list and the token decisions landed before variables.css was written, not after bugs shipped.

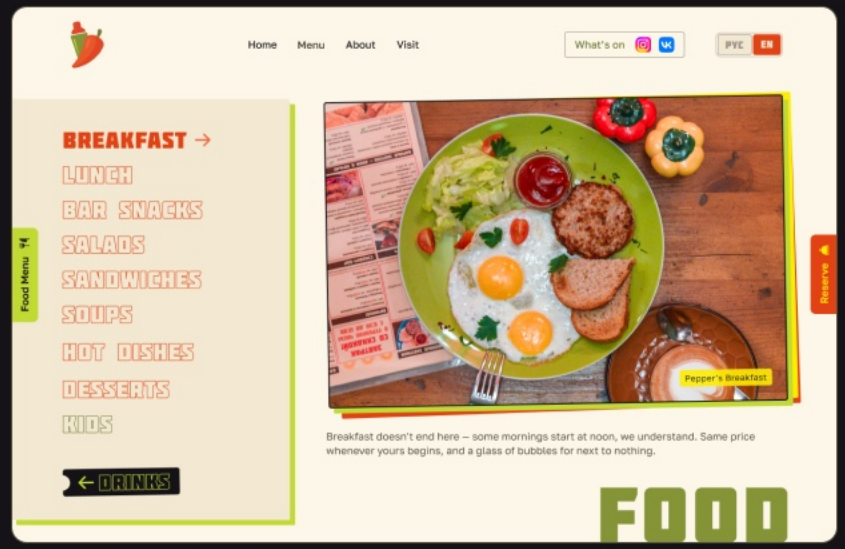
The report captures each component’s states and dimensions as it’s built, so any future chat — or any freelancer in Yaroslavl — inherits a working spec, exactly the handover the stack decision was made for.

BUILDING WITH AI · DESIGN TO CODE

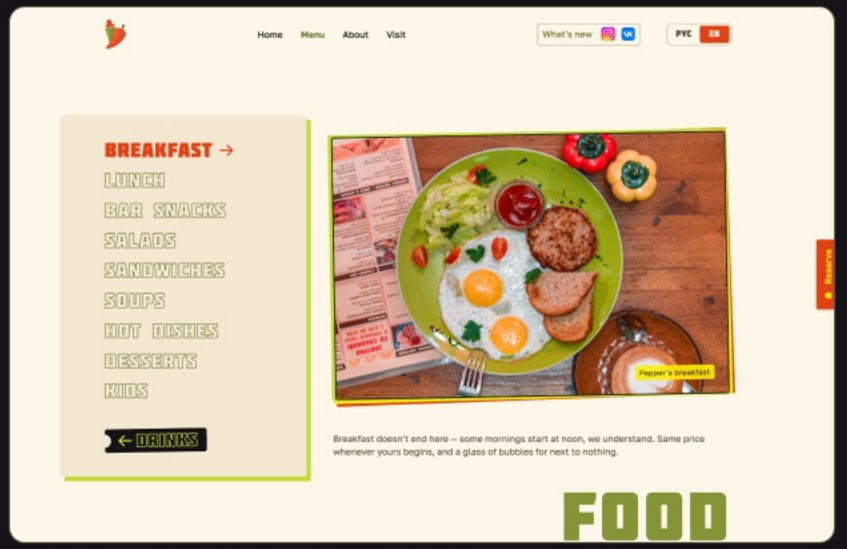
BUILT AS DESIGNED

The Figma frame beside the live page, twice: the kitchen menu by day and the Visit page on a phone. The theme was built from the design files, one section per chat; what moved afterwards moved in the browser, on record.

KITCHEN MENU · DAY · 1280



Figma — July 2026

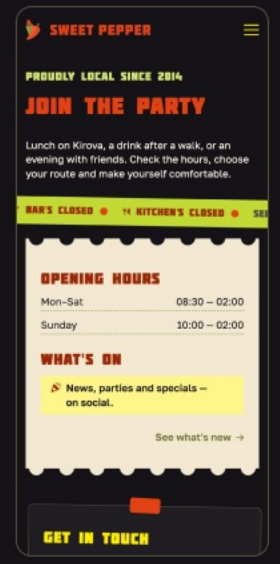


Live — sweetpepper.bar, October 2026

VISIT · PHONE · 402



Figma



Live

PROCESS · THE LAST PHASE, ON SCREEN

SHOWN AS BUILT, NOT AS DRAWN

Three screens from the running site, October 2026. Each was worked out in the browser — options on the live page, a URL flag, then a default; the real-device verdicts are still open.



404 — LOST IN THE SAUCE



PHONE MENU — BAR AT THE FOOT



PAGE LOADER — HEAT AS THE WAIT

CHAPTER 6 OF 6

REAL USE

THE LAW IS A DESIGN CONSTRAINT

A LAWYER AND A STATUTE

Instagram only outside Russia

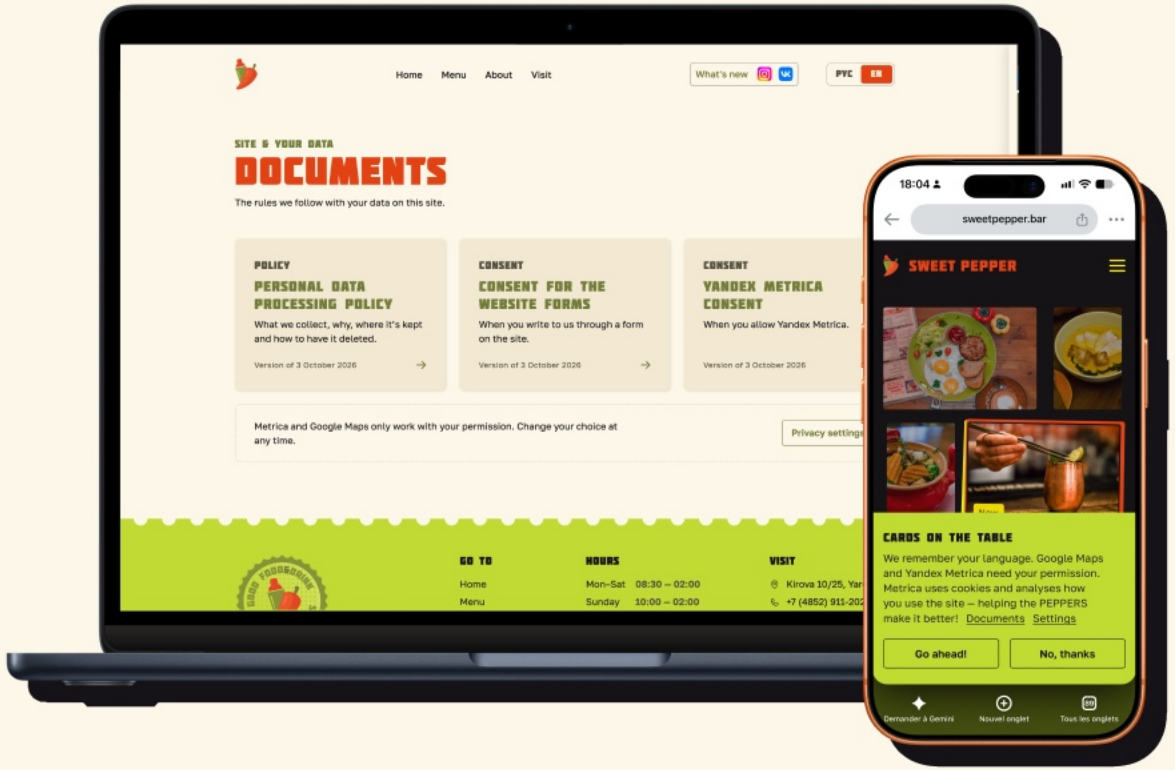
On the lawyer's advice the Russian page never shows it and the English page hides it from Russian IPs — chips, drawers, contact rows, even the structured data. The planned proxy was withdrawn, not built.

Maps wait for a choice

The server renders the address instead of an iframe; a yes lasts 180 days and can be revoked from the footer. A US/Canada exception on the English page was built with the advice against it, then retired with the owner's policy.

The owner's words, a hub, a sheet

Three legal pages in the owner's reviewed words, a Documents hub, a notice with a confirmation step, a settings sheet on phones. Analytics waits until consent can be recorded provably.



PROCESS · THE LAST PHASE

THE SLIDER RETURNS AS THE WAIT

THE RETIRED SLIDER RETURNS

Heat rising is the whole task

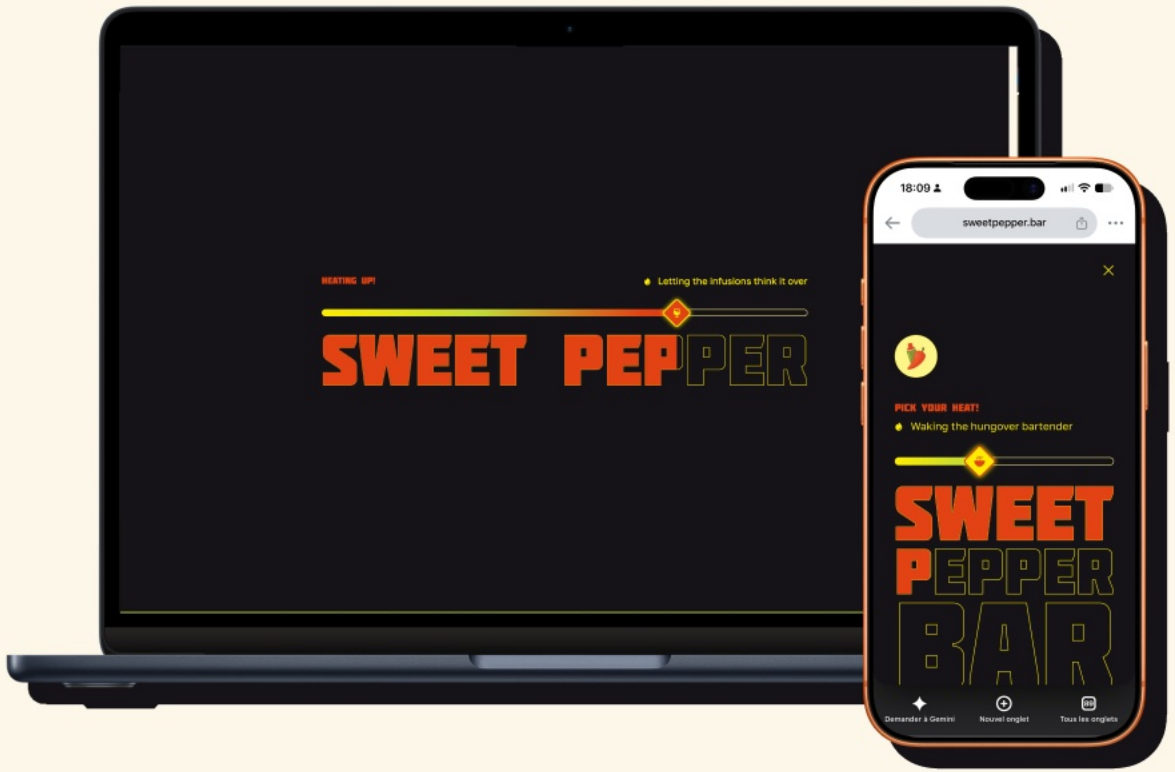
The page loader: the knob moves through breakfast, lunch, dinner and party, the wordmark heats to Chili, the page arrives with «Подано!» — “Served!”. Shown only if a navigation is still pending after 700 ms.

An honest creep

No real progress exists to report, so the knob runs on a curve built to never arrive. The lines under it are the team’s own — “Waking the hungover bartender” — editable in admin.

A replay knows its end

A tester tried to drag the knob, so the footer replay became a toy. Measured, it had borrowed the real wait’s curve: 7 s to “Served!”. Now its own curve — 3.3 s, the close button there from the start.



WHERE IT STANDS

THE SITE IS UP. CHECKS REMAIN.

DONE

- Design system validated; palette pruned (Dark Olive out)
- Style guide live: bilingual HTML, mobile shell, PDFs, edit mode
- All pages, both states, RU + EN: phone, tablet band, desktop
- Heroes, menu storage & the admin all usability-tested
- Content model in use: fall menu, vacancies, the team's own lines
- Site on the bar's domain; VK feed updating itself hourly

NEXT

- Device verdicts: phone menu bar, 404, loader, lightbox
- Page cache, then search engines; analytics once consent is recorded
- Hero photos; the remaining team photos; founder quote
- Figma catch-up; queued tests; the study's own restructure

REFLECTION

WHAT THIS PROJECT TAUGHT ME

SYSTEMIZING BEATS REDESIGNING

The strongest move was often restraint — keeping a logo guests already loved and building rules around it, instead of replacing it to prove originality.

CONSTRAINTS FOUND THE IDEA

The “no-clock” hospitality principle looked like a limitation. It’s actually what forced the spice-slider metaphor instead of a literal schedule widget.

SOME BEST CALLS AREN'T DESIGN CALLS

Ruling out Webflow had nothing to do with aesthetics — OFAC sanctions would have made the site invisible to its own market. Good UX sometimes means researching infrastructure, not layouts.

LOUD COLOUR NEEDS MORE RULES

A playful, saturated brand doesn’t get to skip accessibility — it needs a stricter generative rule (three hue lines) to stay usable at all.

AI ACCELERATES, JUDGMENT CURATES

Six working slider prototypes in one afternoon — but half quietly broke a rule the project had earned. The skill wasn’t prompting; it was knowing which three to discard.

DEVELOPMENT IS A DESIGN REVIEW

Building it myself surfaced limitations no mockup shows — caching, touch input, real pixel sizes — and decisions I was attached to had to be reconsidered. What survived the constraints is stronger for it.



THANK YOU

Sweet Pepper — Brand & UX Case Study · Etual

etual.conceptly@gmail.com